GHAN PROJECTS

Development Feasibility Checklist

The essential 50-point checklist we use to evaluate every development site in Melbourne

Before you buy, subdivide, or develop, check this first

Every development site can look promising at first glance. A block may appear large enough, the location may seem strong, and the resale outcome may look attractive on paper. But once planning controls, title restrictions, servicing constraints, construction complexity, or end-value assumptions are examined properly, the true opportunity often changes.

This is where disciplined feasibility work matters.

At Ghan Projects, we assess development sites with a commercial lens before clients commit serious time, money, or energy. The goal is not simply to determine whether a site can be developed. It is to determine whether it can be developed efficiently, profitably, and with a level of risk that makes sense.

This checklist outlines the key items we review when assessing development sites across Melbourne. It is designed to help landowners, investors, and aspiring developers think more clearly about site potential before purchase, subdivision, or project commencement.

Used properly, this checklist can help you:

- identify risks earlier
- compare multiple sites more objectively
- avoid overestimating yield
- uncover hidden legal or servicing constraints
- make more informed development decisions

A site can be technically developable and still be a poor development deal. Strong projects are usually the result of good decisions made early.

Who this is for

This resource is intended for people evaluating residential development opportunities in Melbourne, especially where early-stage due diligence can materially affect the outcome.

Landowners exploring development potential

If you already own land and want to understand whether it may suit a subdivision, townhouse project, or redevelopment strategy, this checklist provides a structured starting point.

Investors assessing townhouse or subdivision opportunities

For buyers comparing sites, this checklist helps separate superficial appeal from genuine development potential by focusing on the factors that affect yield, cost, timing, and risk.

First-time developers wanting a practical due diligence framework

Development can become expensive very quickly when key issues are missed early. This checklist provides a grounded framework to help first-time developers think more like experienced project operators.

Buyers comparing multiple sites before committing

Where several opportunities are under consideration, a structured checklist improves comparison and reduces emotional decision-making.

How to use it

Use this as an early feasibility and risk-screening tool

This is not a substitute for full consultant advice, but it is an effective first-pass framework for identifying obvious strengths, constraints, and unknowns.

Tick each item before progressing too far

The more items you can confirm early, the clearer your decision-making becomes. Unknowns create risk. Confirmed information creates leverage.

Flag unknowns that need consultant advice

Some issues require input from planners, surveyors, civil engineers, designers, or other consultants. The purpose of this checklist is to make those issues visible early.

Use it to identify deal killers early
One major title issue, servicing problem, planning overlay, or yield limitation can materially change the viability of a site. The earlier those issues are found, the better the decision.

The 50-Point Development Feasibility Checklist

Section 1 — Site Fundamentals

1. Site address confirmed
Confirm the exact property details and ensure all documents refer to the correct lot and title particulars.

2. Land size confirmed
Verify the true site area rather than relying only on marketing material or listing descriptions.

3. Dimensions verified
Check width, depth, and overall geometry through title, survey, or plan information.

4. Frontage width checked
Frontage can materially affect access, design efficiency, subdivision outcomes, and street presentation.

5. Corner site or mid-block position noted
Corner sites may improve access and design flexibility, while mid-block sites may have more layout limitations.

6. Irregular shape flagged
Unusual site geometry can reduce efficiency, yield, and usable built form.

7. Slope/topography reviewed
Changes in level can affect retaining, excavation, drainage, construction cost, and building design.

8. Existing dwelling/demolition implications noted
Review whether demolition is required and whether there are cost, timing, or access implications attached.

9. Vehicle access potential checked
Access must work practically, not just theoretically. Widths, turning movements, and layout feasibility matter.

10. Orientation and solar access reviewed
A site's orientation affects daylight access, open space quality, energy performance, and design efficiency.

Section 2 — Planning Controls

11. Current zoning confirmed
Confirm the applicable planning zone and ensure the intended development type is supported in principle.

12. All overlays identified
Overlays can significantly affect design, process, cost, and referral requirements.

13. Planning permit requirements checked
Clarify which aspects of the proposal are likely to trigger planning approval.

14. Subdivision potential reviewed
Assess whether the site is suitable for subdivision in principle, not just built form development.

15. Multi-dwelling potential assessed
Test whether the site can realistically support the number and type of dwellings being considered.

16. Zone schedule variations reviewed
Some schedules introduce local requirements that materially affect yield or design.

17. ResCode / Clause 55 implications considered
Review whether neighbourhood character, setbacks, overlooking, private open space, and other standards may constrain the concept.

18. Subdivision / Clause 56 implications considered
Where subdivision is proposed, ensure subdivision-specific standards and design responses are considered.

19. Neighbourhood character risks noted
A site may appear feasible numerically but still face planning resistance due to surrounding character.

20. Local policy or special planning controls identified
Municipal policy, local frameworks, and specific precinct controls can materially influence outcome and approval pathway.

Section 3 — Title and Legal Constraints

21. Copy of title reviewed
A current title search should be reviewed as a baseline due diligence item.

22. Plan of subdivision reviewed
The plan may reveal boundaries, easements, common property, and other structural constraints.

23. Easements identified
Easements can sterilise usable land and complicate building footprint, services, and access.

24. Restrictive covenants identified
A covenant can significantly limit redevelopment potential or prevent the intended outcome entirely.

25. Section 173 agreements checked
These agreements may impose obligations or restrictions that affect future use or development.

26. Caveats or encumbrances noted
Additional legal interests should be identified early to avoid surprises later.

27. Building envelope restrictions checked
Some sites are affected by restrictions that limit where and how built form can occur.

28. Access rights or shared access issues checked
Shared driveways or access arrangements can complicate design, legal structure, and function.

29. Adjoining title dependencies noted
Some outcomes may depend on neighbouring land, shared boundaries, or coordinated access arrangements.

30. Legal constraints impact on yield assessed
It is not enough to identify legal constraints — their effect on project yield and viability must also be understood.

Section 4 — Physical and Servicing Constraints

31. Sewer location checked
Sewer location can affect building footprint, engineering solutions, and development cost.

32. Stormwater discharge point checked
If legal point of discharge is difficult or expensive to achieve, feasibility can change quickly.

33. Water connection capacity reviewed
Confirm whether the intended development can be serviced efficiently.

34. Power/pits/poles constraints noted
Existing electrical infrastructure can affect access, crossover position, and construction logistics.

35. Build-over-easement risk checked
Building near or over easements may trigger restrictions, approvals, or design loss.

36. Crossover constraints checked
Vehicle crossing conditions and location may affect site planning and parking configuration.

37. Significant trees or vegetation constraints noted
Tree protection requirements can materially affect layout, yield, and approval risk.

38. Drainage complexity assessed
Complex drainage design can increase civil cost and reduce overall margin.

39. Excavation/retaining wall risk flagged
Retaining structures and heavy excavation often add significant cost that is underestimated early.

40. Waste and servicing layout practicality checked
A concept may stack up on paper but fail operationally if waste, bins, servicing access, or utility layouts are impractical.

Section 5 — Environmental and Risk Factors

41. Flood risk checked
Flood exposure can affect floor levels, design response, insurance, and overall site viability.

42. Authority referral risk identified
Some sites may trigger external referral authorities, which can add time, conditions, and complexity.

43. Floor level or flood certificate requirements noted
Additional reporting or build requirements should be identified early, especially where they affect cost.

44. Contamination risk from past land use assessed
Previous industrial, commercial, or unknown uses may create remediation or investigation requirements.

45. Need for environmental investigation flagged
Where risk indicators exist, further investigation should be considered before progressing too far.

46. Bushfire or other environmental overlay risk checked
Environmental controls can materially change design, cost, and development pathway.

Section 6 — Yield and Design Efficiency

47. Likely dwelling yield tested
The realistic yield should be tested conservatively, not based on best-case assumptions.

48. Indicative product mix tested
The proposed mix should suit both the site and the likely market, rather than chasing maximum count alone.

49. Parking/loading/waste layout works in principle
If these core operational elements do not work efficiently, the scheme may not be practical even if it fits numerically.

50. Private open space, setbacks, and built form efficiency tested
The design must work as a whole. Efficient built form is often the difference between a marginal site and a strong one.

Why this checklist matters

Most development mistakes do not happen during construction. They happen earlier, when buyers commit to a site without properly understanding the planning controls, servicing implications, legal constraints, design limitations, and commercial realities attached to it.

The purpose of feasibility is not to slow a project down. It is to reduce the chance of making an expensive decision on incomplete information.

A disciplined site review improves confidence, sharpens assumptions, and helps define whether a project should move forward, be reworked, or be rejected altogether.

Common reasons we reject sites

Not every site with development potential is worth pursuing. In practice, many opportunities fall away once the real constraints are understood.

Restrictive covenant limits the intended outcome
A title covenant may prevent the density, building type, or layout required for the project to work.

Easement sterilises too much of the site
If the easement consumes a critical portion of the developable area, yield and design efficiency can be materially affected.

Flood or overlay constraints materially affect feasibility
A site may still be technically developable, but extra requirements can reduce profitability or introduce unacceptable risk.

Slope and site works destroy margin
What looks manageable at first can become a costly engineering problem once retaining, excavation, and drainage are priced properly.

Yield is lower than expected
Many poor deals begin with an unrealistic assumption about how many dwellings the site can support.

Access and parking layout is weak
If access is compromised or parking outcomes are inefficient, the concept may become impractical or difficult to approve.

Servicing and drainage costs are too high
Utility and civil solutions can quickly erode project margin, especially where upgrades or complex connections are required.

Demolition or construction complexity is underestimated
Existing site conditions, access limitations, or buildability issues can add time and cost beyond what was assumed.

Environmental risk creates too much uncertainty
Where contamination, flood, vegetation, or other environmental factors remain unclear, the project risk profile may become too high.

End values do not justify the project risk
Even a well-designed project can be the wrong decision if the projected sales or end value does not support the cost, complexity, and exposure involved.

> A site can be developable and still be a poor development deal. The goal is not just to find potential, but to find viable potential.

Want us to assess your site properly?

Ghan Projects helps Melbourne landowners and investors assess development opportunities with a practical, commercially focused approach.

We look beyond surface-level potential to identify the planning, title, design, servicing, and feasibility factors that can materially affect the outcome of a project. That means clearer decisions, fewer hidden surprises, and a better understanding of whether a site is genuinely worth pursuing.

Whether you are considering a townhouse development, subdivision, redevelopment of an existing property, or evaluating a site before purchase, we help bring structure and decision clarity to the process.

Our services include

- Site feasibility reviews
- Development strategy
- Acquisition due diligence
- Risk identification
- Consultant coordination

Professional Consultation